1.1 Jefferson's Vision for America

John Adams and Thomas Jefferson didn't actually come to blows during the election of 1800, but they probably came close. They certainly exchanged insults. But when the dust settled, Jefferson was the winner.

MAIN IDEA After the election of Thomas Jefferson, the nation steered a course to a more limited and less expensive government.

BREAKING THE TIE

The election of 1800 was filled with tension and political divisions, and the fact that the frontrunners were the **incumbent**, or current, president and vice president added to it. President Adams, the Federalist, had spent the past four years building a strong government. Vice President Thomas Jefferson, the Democratic-Republican, believed Adams had favored businessmen from the North. To persuade the nation to elect him, Jefferson promised a limited government and lower taxes.

Jefferson favored Aaron Burr as his candidate for vice president. But remember that, at that time, potential running mates ran on their own. So for Burr to become Jefferson's vice president, Jefferson needed to receive the most votes, and Burr needed to come in second.

As it turned out, Jefferson and Burr received an equal number of votes for president. The tie had to be broken by the Federalist-dominated House of Representatives.



Replicas of Burr-Hamilton dueling pistols

New York Historical Society, New York

In the early 1800s, men engaged in pistol fights called duels to defend their honor. Although dueling was illegal in most states, it was an accepted practice.

On the morning of July 11, 1804, Vice President Aaron Burr and Alexander Hamilton dueled in a field in Weehawken, New Jersey. Burr had challenged Hamilton to the duel; Hamilton had provided the pistols. The men's rivalry had been building for a decade. In 1791, Burr defeated Hamilton's father-in-law in an election. In 1800, Burr publicly shamed Hamilton by publishing a private essay Hamilton had written criticizing his fellow Federalist, President John Adams. The final straw for Burr was when he read a newspaper article that quoted some of Hamilton's negative opinions of him.

Before that fateful morning, Hamilton had written in letters that he had no intention of killing Burr. The aim of Hamilton's first shot is disputed. Some say he pointed his pistol up in the air; others say he fired at Burr and missed. But Burr didn't miss. He shot Hamilton in the stomach, and Hamilton died the next day. Not only did the showdown end Hamilton's life, it also ended the vice president's political career. Burr was charged with Hamilton's death but received no punishment for the crime.

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The World's Best Hope

Jefferson tried to unite Americans in his 1801 Inaugural Address and soothe their fears about what had happened in France during the French Revolution. In that country, radical elements in a republican government had seized control and terrorized the French people. In this excerpt from his address, Jefferson explains why he doesn't believe such a thing could happen in the United States. Why does Jefferson believe the United States has the strongest government on earth?

PRIMARY SOURCE

I know, indeed, that some honest men fear that a republican government can not be strong, that this Government is not strong enough, but would the honest patriot . . . abandon a government which has so far kept us free and firm on the theoretic and visionary [imaginary] fear that this Government, the world's best hope, may . . . want [lack] energy to preserve itself? I trust not. I believe this, on the contrary, the strongest Government on earth. I believe it the only one where every man . . . would meet invasions of the public order [would defend the country] as his own personal concern.

—from Thomas Jefferson's First Inaugural Address, March 4, 1801

The House spent six days casting votes 36 separate times. At first, most Federalists supported Burr, but Burr's bitter enemy Alexander Hamilton rallied support for Jefferson. On February 17, 1801, the House cast the final votes. Jefferson became the nation's third president, and Burr became his vice president.

SOOTHING FEARS

Jefferson's inauguration took place the following month, the first to be held in the new capital city of Washington, D.C. The new president was aware of the division in the country following the election. Many Federalists feared what they considered Jefferson's radical views. They saw what had happened during the French Revolution, when extreme revolutionaries took control and executed thousands of people. In his inaugural address, Jefferson tried to soothe their fears by saying, "We are all Republicans; we are all Federalists."

Jefferson's call for unity set the tone for his years in office. He clearly laid out his plan for governing to the people—and followed it. He lowered taxes and reduced the size of the federal judiciary. In addition, Jefferson continued to support the power of the states and championed low government spending. But he did not dismantle all Federalist institutions. He left the military and Hamilton's National Bank mostly intact.

A popular president, Jefferson easily won re-election in 1804. In his second term, Jefferson continued to combine Democratic-Republican beliefs with wise politics, shrinking the federal government, military, and national debt. Further, Jefferson's personal humility, or humbleness, went hand-in-hand with his philosophy of small government. Instead of hosting showy and expensive events, he insisted on meeting personally with members of Congress and foreign leaders for dinner and conversation. A seat at that table would have been a sought-after invitation for most. These dinners showcased not only Jefferson's taste for fine food but also his many talents.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was Thomas Jefferson's political philosophy, and how was it reflected in his policies as president?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Based on what you have learned about the ideological differences between Jefferson and Hamilton, what can you infer about Hamilton's support of Jefferson in the 1800 election?
3. **DISTINGUISH FACT AND OPINION** What facts and opinions does Jefferson use to reduce the country's fears and unite Americans?

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